process the poem in the same way I did before. While translating Ovid, I'd say I use the Italian side of myself much more than the English side."

By any standards, Lahiri is a linguistic savant: other than Bengali and English, of course, she has studied French, Latin, Russian and ancient Greek. She has said that she doesn't think in any particular language, that the choice of project or story guides her in this context. It's a remarkable state of lingual tabula rasa, then, that Lahiri operates from. I've interviewed major writers from around the world for well over a decade now and I can't think of another practitioner with a comparable approach.

"I have always seen all languages as foreign languages," says Lahiri. "I have no mother tongue. I always knew that I had an imperfect relationship with Bengali, my first language, especially since I didn't live among Bengali speakers. Until I was five years old, I spoke no English and after I learned the language, it was all I spoke while I was with my classmates. At the same time, I was very conscious of the fact that I had to switch back to Bengali as soon as I returned home, as soon as I crossed that threshold. And so I have always viewed all languages as inherently 'foreign', as something outside of myself."

Lahiri and Baraz's co-translation of *The Metamorphoses* seeks to iron out archaic usages and bring the text into the contemporary era, especially from the point of view of younger readers. Across the last decade, the British-American classicist Emily Wilson has gained a lot of traction among younger readers with her 'modernised' translations of *The Odyssey* (2017) and *The Iliad* (2023). Hopefully, Lahiri and Baraz will be able to achieve something similar with *The Metamorphoses*, opening up Ovid's work to a whole new generation. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS ▼

Ode to Memory

IN *THE LITTLE BOOK OF GOODBYES*, RAVI SHANKAR ETTETH TURNS PARTING AND LOSS INTO SOMETHING QUIETLY RESTORATIVE

Organised as a loosely connected mass of friends-and-family lore, Ravi Shankar Etteth's *The Little Book of Goodbyes* is a highly unusual and, given its theme of deaths and other kinds of farewells, oddly comforting collection of memories. Note that I said 'memories' and not 'anecdotes', because 'anecdote' evokes traditional plotting. A memory is an untamed beast with no narrative constraints at all. This allows Etteth to pepper his stories with literary allusions, historiographic observations and counterintuitive life lessons.

Within these 150-odd pages, we meet the writer's formidable grandfather, a commandant in the Malabar Special Police in the 1920s and '30s, tasked with fighting the Moplah Rebellion, a mandate that ends up defining his view of humanity. Every bit as interesting is his grandmother, an illiterate woman who could nevertheless slip into raconteur mode with "the flair of a Malayali Jane Austen and the eye of a Frida Kahlo". There's the terminally ill friend who wants one last hand of cards, a teller of tall tales called 'Nonayan Master' ('Nonayan' is 'liar' in Malayalam) and the endlessly resourceful Ramaswamy, scene-stealer in several of these stories. Each story has been told with wit, compassion and a clear-eyed pragmatism that has no time for shallow nostalgia.

EACH OF THE STORIES IS TOLD WITH WIT, COMPASSION AND A CLEAR-EYED PRAGMATISM

At his best, Etteth channels the subversive cruelty found in Roald Dahl's stories, like 'Lamb to the Slaughter' and 'The Way up to Heaven'. Indeed, one of the book's best chapters, 'A Dragonfly Story', begins by noting that writers like Roald Dahl and William Golding understood children's capacity for unthinking cruelty, that Golding's novel *Lord of the Flies* had destroyed Etteth's faith in innocence.

And yet, there is a confessional earnestness in these stories of stubborn grandparents and incorrigible uncles. As Etteth notes in the foreword, "The French are wrong. When you say goodbye, a part of you doesn't die. It changes into something stronger." *The Little Book of Goodbyes* is about that 'something stronger' and how all of us are searching for it in our own ways. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha



THE LITTLE BOOK OF GOODBYES
By Ravi Shankar Etteth
WESTLAND
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